



MERMAID BOAT TOURS JAX

Frequently Asked Questions: Inshore Scenic Tours & Sandbar Excursions

Welcome aboard! To help you prepare for your upcoming private charter through the beautiful coastal waters of North Florida, please see below a complete list of the most frequently asked questions.

Booking, Safety, & Legal Guidelines

- **What does a USCG OUPV ("6-Pack") licensed captain mean for my charter?**
It means your trip is commanded by a professional certified by the United States Coast Guard. This credential requires hundreds of hours of documented sea time, rigorous testing, and background screening. The "6-Pack" designation means our vessel is legally rated to carry a **maximum of 6 passengers**, ensuring a private, uncrowded, and highly personalized experience.
 - **We have 7 people in our group, but two are small toddlers. Can we all come?**
No. Federal maritime law counts every single human being as a passenger, regardless of age or size. A baby or toddler counts toward the limit exactly the same as an adult. Our legal limit is strictly **6 passengers plus the captain**.
 - **Is the captain drug-tested?**
Yes. All USCG-licensed captains are required by federal law to be enrolled in a strict, mandatory **Department of Transportation (DOT) random drug testing program**.
 - **Are life jackets required to be worn the entire time?**
By federal law, children **under the age of 13** must wear a USCG-approved life jacket at all times while the vessel is underway (moving). For adults, life jackets are provided and easily accessible, but wearing them is optional while cruising or anchored at the sandbar – as long as adults are self-identified as competent swimmers.
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Weather, Cancellation, & Pet Policies

- **What is your cancellation policy regarding bad weather?**
Safety is our absolute priority. The captain closely monitors local radar and NOAA marine forecasts leading up to your trip. If the captain determines that **inclement weather** (such as high winds, lightning, or heavy downpours) makes conditions unsafe to operate, the charter will be canceled or postponed.
- **What are my options if the captain cancels for weather?**
If the captain cancels the trip due to forecasted weather before departure, you will receive the option to **reschedule for a future date**. *Note:* Cloudiness, a light passing sprinkle, or a less-than-

perfect forecast do not automatically trigger a cancellation. The final decision rests entirely with the captain.

- **Are pets allowed onboard for scenic tours or sandbar trips?**

No, pets are not permitted onboard. For the safety, comfort, and cleanliness of our vessel, as well as the safety of your animals around deep water and unfamiliar marine life, we enforce a strict **no pets allowed** policy. Fully trained service animals covered under the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) are permitted, but please notify us in advance so we can ensure the proper accommodation arrangements are in place.

Meetup Locations & Parking

- **Where do we meet the captain and board the boat?**

Because we service different scenic routes and sandbars across North Florida, our **exact boat ramp meetup location will be confirmed with you at the time of booking**. Common meetup points include local public boat ramps and marinas in Jacksonville, St. Augustine, or Amelia Island. Your captain will send you a direct map link and instructions 24 hours before departure.

- **Is there parking available at the meetup locations?**

Yes. All of our selected meetup locations feature on-site public parking. Please arrive **15 to 20 minutes prior to your scheduled departure time** to ensure you find a spot, gather your belongings, and maximize your time on the water. Be sure to follow any local parking signs or fee boxes where applicable.

What to Expect & Wildlife Guide

- **What should we expect during a sandbar excursion in the summertime?**

North Florida features incredible tidal sandbars (like those near Fort George Island or the Matanzas River). We will anchor in shallow, pristine water. You can hop off the boat, swim, look for shells, relax in the water, or use any floating amenities we provide. **Water depths change with the tides**, varying from ankle-deep to waist-deep. Pineapple Point in the St. Johns River (south of Doctors Lake) is a tide-exempted sandbar location; expect 2.5-4ft depth at all times.

- **What kind of wildlife will we see during our inshore tour?**

North Florida's coastal salt marshes and estuaries are thriving ecosystems. Depending on the season and tide, you can expect to see a rich variety of marine life and coastal birds, including **Bottlenose Dolphins** hunting for fish, **West Indian Manatees** traveling through shallow creeks during warmer months, and coastal bird species like bald eagles, osprey, brown pelicans, and roseate spoonbills.

- **Are we guaranteed to see dolphins or manatees?**

While our captain knows the local waters intimately and will take you to the area's top wildlife "hotspots," these are wild animals in their natural habitat. Because of this, **wildlife sightings cannot be 100% guaranteed**, but it is highly unusual to complete a tour without spotting some of North Florida's unique coastal residents!

- **Can we swim with or feed the dolphins and manatees if we see them?**

No. All marine mammals are strictly protected by federal law under the Marine Mammal Protection Act. It is illegal to feed, touch, harass, or swim directly to them. Our captain ensures we maintain a safe, respectful legal distance so you can capture incredible photos and enjoy watching them behave naturally without disruption.

Onboard Amenities, Footwear, & Packing

- **Is there a restroom available onboard?**

Yes. For your comfort and convenience, our vessel is equipped with a private **marine porta-potty** tucked inside the designated center console changing area. While it is cleanly maintained, fully functional and available for use during the cruise, we always highly recommend using a land-based restroom at the marina right before we cast off.

- **What kind of footwear should we wear for the charter?**

- **While Onboard:** Wear comfortable, flat, **non-marking shoes** (such as boat shoes, sneakers, or rubber-soled sandals). Please avoid any shoes with black soles, high heels, or boots, as these can scuff or damage the deck.
- **At the Sandbar:** Because you will be stepping off the boat into shallow water, flip-flops, slides, or water shoes are perfect. Most passengers prefer to go completely barefoot while relaxing on the boat and sandbar.
- **Pro-Tip:** Watch out for sharp oyster shells in North Florida's tidal creeks! If you plan to explore beyond the main sandy areas of the sandbar, bringing a pair of **mesh water shoes** is highly recommended.

- **What is included in the charter, and what should we bring?**

- **We Provide:** All required USCG safety gear, life jackets, a licensed captain, cooler with ice, bottled water, and local digital navigation charts.
 - **You Should Bring:** Polarized sunglasses (best for spotting marine life), reef-safe sunscreen, towels, hats, snacks, and any preferred drinks.
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Food & Beverage Guidelines

- **What kind of food and snacks should we bring?**

You are welcome to bring whatever food you like! Easy-to-eat **finger foods, sandwiches, wraps, chips, fruit, and sub platters** work best on the boat. We suggest avoiding messy foods or items that melt easily in the Florida sun.

- **Can we bring our own drinks and alcohol?**

Yes. You are welcome to bring your favorite sodas, juices, and alcoholic beverages (for passengers 21+). We **strongly recommend canned or plastic-bottled beverages** instead of glass, as glass bottles break easily on a moving vessel.

- **Do we need to bring our own cooler?**

We provide a large onboard cooler stocked with fresh ice and complimentary bottled water. You are welcome to use our space to keep your food and drinks cold, but you can also bring a small personal cooler if you prefer to keep your items separate.

Alcohol, Tipping, & Payment Methods

- **Are illegal substances allowed if we stay in Florida state waters?**

Absolutely not. Because the vessel is under federal Coast Guard jurisdiction, **federal law applies at all times**. This means all illegal drugs, including recreational or medical marijuana, are strictly prohibited on board. Bringing these substances will result in the immediate cancellation of the charter with no refund.

- **Is tipping the captain required, and how much is customary?**

While gratuity is never strictly mandatory, it is **highly customary and greatly appreciated** for a job well done! Much like the hospitality industry, a standard tip for a charter captain ranges between **15% to 20% of the total charter price**. If the captain worked hard to keep you safe, find wildlife, and make your sandbar excursion memorable, a tip at the end of the trip is the best way to show your appreciation.

- **What payment methods are accepted for tipping or remaining balances?**

Payment is due when charter service concludes at the point of debarkation. For your convenience, we accept several digital and traditional payment options for the **2026 rate of \$150/hr**. Currently accepting Venmo (@Erin-Homan-9), Zelle (search by 904-553-9598 or erinhoman@gmail.com), or CashApp (\$ehoman83). You can easily take care of gratuities or any onboard incidentals via cash payment (always preferred for captain tips). Because cell service can occasionally be spotty in certain North Florida areas, we recommend having your digital payment apps set up ahead of time!

Contact & Booking Information

- **How do I book a charter or get in touch with questions?**

We are ready to welcome you out on the water! To reserve your date, check current availability, or ask specific questions about customizing your itinerary, please reach out to Captain Erin directly:

- **Phone/Text (*Preferred*):** 904-553-9598
- **Email:** erinhoman@gmail.com
- **Website:** <https://mermaidboattoursjax.com/>